



AUBURN UNIVERSITY

College of Forestry, Wildlife and Environment

INFORMATION LETTER

(NOTE: DO NOT AGREE TO PARTICIPATE UNLESS AN IRB APPROVAL STAMP WITH CURRENT DATES HAS BEEN APPLIED TO THIS DOCUMENT.)

Title of research study: *“Backyard bird behavior and disease: Participant Surveys”*

Investigator: Dr. Allie McCreary; phone: 334-844-1059; email: aem0200@auburn.edu

Sponsor: None.

You are invited to participate in a research study to examine the motivations, behaviors, and perceptions of individuals who engage in backyard bird feeding and/or backyard poultry keeping. This research will be conducted through a survey questionnaire which will ask about your attachment to your property, your awareness of diseases that can spread between wild birds, poultry, and humans, and your conservation-related attitudes and actions. The study is being conducted by (Alex Fisher, MSc. Student), under the direction of (Drs. Kelsey McCune, PhD and Allie McCreary, PhD.) in the Auburn University College of Forestry, Wildlife and Environment. You were selected as a possible participant because you are an adult (18 years of age or older) who maintains backyard bird feeders, keeps backyard poultry, or has interest or knowledge of these activities in the Southeastern United States. You may have received this invitation because you take part in our Backyard Birds field study, or through an Alabama Cooperative Extension System email listserv or newsletter.

What will be involved if you participate? If you decide to participate in this research study, you will be asked to complete a confidential online survey about your backyard wildlife feeding practices, your perceptions of avian disease risk, and your conservation-related attitudes and behaviors. Your total time commitment will be approximately 10-15 minutes.

Are there any risks or discomforts? The risks associated with participating in this study are minimal and limited to the possible discomfort of answering questions about your personal practices and opinions. To minimize these risks, your participation is voluntary, you may skip any question you prefer not to answer, and all responses are kept confidential.

Are there any benefits to yourself or others? There are no direct benefits to the participant. The information gained may help researchers better understand backyard wildlife feeding practices and the risks of disease transmission among wild birds, poultry, and humans. We cannot promise you that you will receive any or all of the benefits described.

Will you receive compensation for participating? There is no compensation for participating in this study.

Are there any costs? If you decide to participate, the only cost will be the time used to take the survey. Auburn University has not provided for any payment if you are harmed as a result of participating in this study.

If you change your mind about participating, you can withdraw at any time during the study. Your participation is completely voluntary. You can skip any question in the survey or stop taking the survey at any time. If you take part in our Backyard Birds field study, you may ask to have your responses withdrawn before data analysis begins by contacting Alex Fisher and referencing your household's site code. If you are not part of the field study, your responses are anonymous and cannot be withdrawn once submitted because they cannot be linked to you. Your decision about

whether to participate or to stop participating will not jeopardize your future relations with Auburn University or the College of Forestry, Wildlife and the Environment.

Any data obtained in connection with this study will remain confidential. We will protect your privacy and the data you provide by not collecting or distributing any personally identifying information, such as your name, email address, or precise location, and by reporting all findings in aggregate (such as the average response across multiple participants for any one question). If you take part in our Backyard Birds field study, your responses will be labeled with your household's site code rather than your name so they can be linked to the bird data collected in your yard; the list linking site codes to households is stored separately and securely. If you are not part of the field study, your responses are anonymous. Information collected through your participation may be used to fulfill an educational requirement (in a student thesis), published in a professional journal, and/or presented at a professional meeting.

If you have questions about this study, please ask them now or contact Alex Fisher at amf0080@auburn.edu, Dr. Allie McCreary at aem0200@auburn.edu, or Dr. Kelsey McCune at kbm0054@auburn.edu.

If you have questions about your rights as a research participant, you may contact the Auburn University Office of Research Compliance or the Institutional Review Board by phone (334) 844-5966 or e-mail at IRBadmin@auburn.edu or IRBChair@auburn.edu.

HAVING READ THE INFORMATION PROVIDED, YOU MUST DECIDE IF YOU WANT TO PARTICIPATE IN THIS RESEARCH PROJECT. IF YOU DECIDE TO PARTICIPATE, THE DATA YOU PROVIDE WILL SERVE AS YOUR AGREEMENT TO DO SO. THIS LETTER IS YOURS TO KEEP.